

SHARPENING CHEAT SHEET

Angles, grits and strops — by knife type. Numbers are per side, measured off the stone. Laminate this page and hang it where you sharpen.

EDGE ANGLE BY KNIFE TYPE

KNIFE	PER SIDE	WHY
Straight razor	7–9°	Pure slicing, zero lateral load
Fillet / sushi	12–15°	Effortless slicing in soft flesh
Kitchen chef / paring	15–20°	Sharpness first; the steel sets how low you dare
EDC / pocket	17–20°	Daily cutting + some abuse
Hunting / skinner	16–20°	Start at 18°. Premium steel holds 16° through bone
Bushcraft / camp	18–25°	Batoning, carving — harder steels run the low end
Machete / axe	25–30°	Impact first, sharpness second

The steel sets the floor: better steel = lower angle for the same job. A CruWear, 3V or MagnaCut hunter holds 16° and hits bone with no problem; budget stainless wants 20°. When in doubt: start 20°, work down as the steel earns your trust.

HOLD THE ANGLE — THREE TRICKS

Coin stack	Two quarters under the spine of a 1.5" blade ≈ 15°. Cheap training wheels.
Sharpie trick	Ink the bevel, two passes, look where ink is gone. Adjust until the full bevel wipes clean.
Lock the wrist	Move from the shoulder. The wrist changes angle; the shoulder doesn't.

GRIT LADDER

STAGE	GRIT	USE WHEN
Repair	220–400	Chips, rolled edge, reprofiling the bevel
Sharpen	600–1000	The workhorse stage. Raise a burr full length, both sides
Refine	2000–3000	Clean up scratches, chase the burr smaller
Polish	5000–8000	Push-cut hair-whittling territory. Kitchen + razors
Strop	compound	Every session ends here. Also revives an edge for weeks

Skip grits, waste time: each stage must fully erase the scratches of the one before. Doubling the grit number per step is the fastest ladder.

STROP COMPOUNDS

COMPOUND	~MICRON	JOB
Black (emery)	~30μ	Heavy cutting, almost a stone
White (alum. oxide)	~3μ	Mid polish, daily maintenance
Green (chrom. oxide)	~0.5μ	Finish polish, scary sharp
Bare leather	—	Aligns the edge, removes nothing

THE 5-STEP ROUTINE

1	Mark the bevel with a Sharpie. Set your angle.
2	Low grit until a burr runs the FULL edge on one side. Flip, repeat.
3	Climb the ladder. Lighter pressure every stage.
4	Strop 10–15 passes per side, edge trailing, angle slightly low.
5	Test: slice printer paper, then shave arm hair. Fail → back one grit.